

Labor-Market Outcomes of Former Student-Visa Holders

2023 National Survey of College Graduates

Institute for Progress

September 14, 2026

Overview

This report analyzes the labor-market outcomes of **student-visa entrants** — people whose first U.S. visa was a student visa — compared with **natives**, using the 2023 National Survey of College Graduates (NSCG) public-use microdata. The research and federal-support sections additionally distinguish those who are *currently* on a student visa.

Data and definitions

- **Source:** NCSES 2023 NSCG public-use file (Sept. 11, 2025 release); 94,606 respondents.
- **Student visa entrants** = first U.S. visa was a student visa (FNVSATP code 3; n=8,577). **Native** = U.S. native, no entry visa (FNVSATP code L; n=69,286). Unless a section says otherwise, “student visa” columns refer to entrants, not to those currently on a student visa.
- **Working universe** (all salary tables): full-time, full-year workers — 50+ weeks/year (WKSLYR>49), 35+ hours/week (HRSWK>34), and non-missing salary (SALARY≠9,999,998).
- **Weights:** all population estimates use the survey weight WTSURVY; medians are weighted (`matrixStats::weightedMedian`).
- **Self-employment rate** = self-employed workers (EMTP 12 or 13) as a share of *all* workers in the group, i.e. self-employed ÷ (self-employed + not self-employed).
- **Federal agency support:** whether the respondent’s principal-job work was supported by a U.S. federal agency (GOVSUP) and, if so, which agencies (FS*, “mark all that apply”). Agency shares overlap and need not sum to the “any federal support” figure.
- **Basic / applied research:** whether the respondent spent at least 10% of a typical work week on basic research (WABRSH) or applied research (WAAPRSH) on the principal job.
- **Student-visa groupings** (research and federal-support sections): *current student visa holders* = held a student/training visa on Feb. 1, 2023 (VSATP); *student visa entrants* = first U.S. visa was a student visa (FNVSATP). Each is compared with all other full-time/full-year workers.

- **Caveat:** the public-use file omits stratum/PSU identifiers, so these are point estimates without design-based standard errors; small cells (some industries and sender countries) are noisy.

1 Headline salary comparison

Among full-time, full-year workers, student-visa entrants have a substantially higher median salary than natives.

Table 1: Median annual salary, full-time/full-year workers

First visa type	Median salary
Native	\$87,000
Student visa entrants	\$115,249

2 Salary by age (decade)

Table 2: Median salary by age bucket

Age bucket	Native	Student visa entrants
20s	\$62,000	\$81,896
30s	\$88,000	\$117,522
40s	\$100,000	\$130,000
50s	\$100,000	\$124,729
60+	\$99,945	\$110,000

3 Salary by degree level

Table 3: Median salary by most-recent-degree type (BA / MA / PhD / Professional)

Visa type	BA	MA	PhD	Prof
Native	\$80,000	\$95,000	\$112,000	\$150,000
Student visa entrants	\$80,000	\$125,000	\$130,000	\$112,321

4 Degree-level composition

Student-visa entrants are far more concentrated in graduate degrees (MA/PhD) than natives.

Table 4: Distribution of most-recent-degree type, by group (weighted shares within group)

Degree	Native share	Student-visa-entrant share
BA	65.1%	28.8%
MA	26.1%	47.2%
PhD	2.9%	19.0%
Prof	5.9%	5.0%

5 Salary by industry

Table 5: Median salary by industry group (industries with very few international graduates — Agriculture, Military, Wholesale Trade — are excluded, per the source script)

Industry	Native	Student visa entrants
Information	\$100,000	\$186,434
Prof services	\$102,000	\$140,000
Manufacturing	\$106,000	\$130,000
FIRE	\$100,000	\$120,551
Retail Trade	\$80,000	\$110,000
Trans/WH, Util	\$101,000	\$110,000
Public Admin	\$85,000	\$99,288
Accom & Food	\$63,820	\$95,817
Other Services	\$58,000	\$87,375
Ed and HC	\$72,500	\$75,000

6 Salary by country of birth

Top ten sending countries among student-visa entrants, ranked by estimated number of graduates.

Table 6: Median salary and estimated graduate counts, top 10 countries of birth (student-visa entrants)

Country of birth	Median salary	Est. graduates
India	\$146,000	372,042
China	\$125,000	303,420
Korea, South	\$75,686	64,307
Taiwan	\$106,390	55,029
Nigeria	\$80,000	48,554
Iran	\$110,000	46,698
Canada	\$120,000	46,615
Mexico	\$98,000	42,537
Japan	\$90,000	42,143
Germany	\$105,000	31,557

7 Research activity

Student-visa entrants are more than twice as likely as natives to have research as a primary or secondary activity on their principal job.

Table 7: Share whose principal-job primary or secondary activity is basic or applied research (ACTRES), weighted

Visa type	Research (wt.)	No research (wt.)	Research rate
Native	4,356,564	31,448,588	12.2%
Student visa entrants	474,090	1,281,470	27.0%

8 Basic and applied research

Share of full-time/full-year workers who spend at least 10% of a typical work week on basic or applied research, shown two ways: by whether the respondent is *currently* on a student visa, and by whether their *first* U.S. visa was a student visa. “All other workers” is everyone else (natives and other immigrants). The student-visa group leads on both measures under either definition.

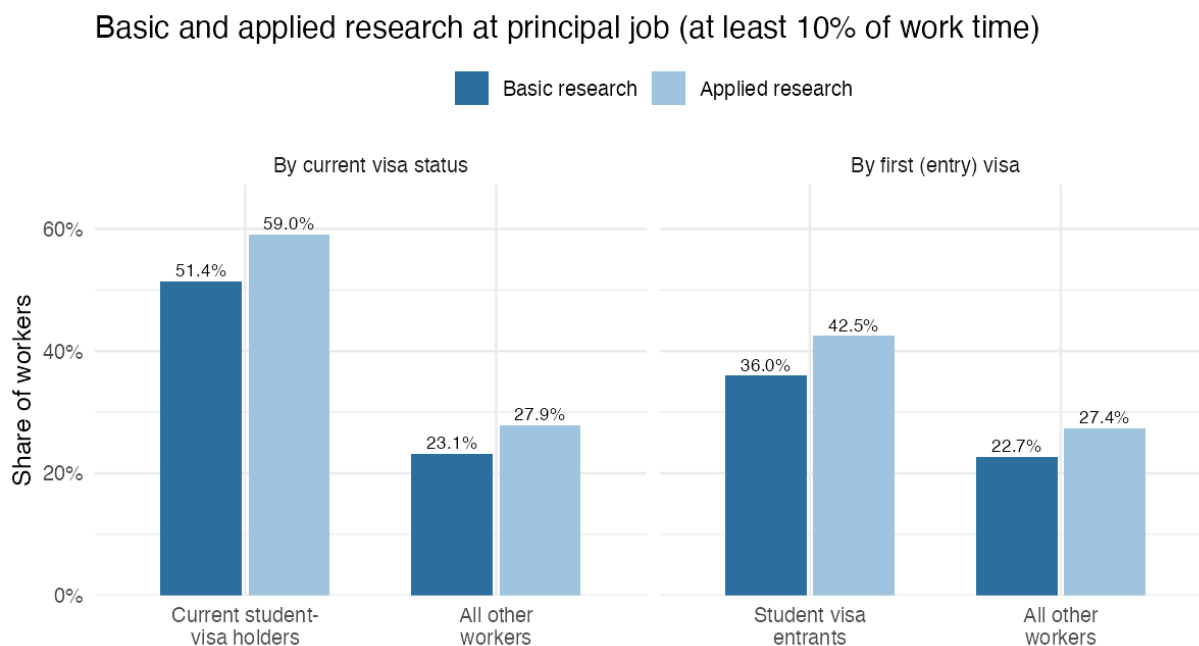


Figure 1: Basic and applied research at the principal job (at least 10% of work time)

Table 8: Basic and applied research, by current student-visa status

Research activity	Current student visa holders	All other workers	
Basic research	51.4%	23.1%	<i>Universe: full-time/full-year workers. Unweighted n: current student visa = 557; all other workers = 64,072.</i>
Applied research	59.0%	27.9%	

Table 9: Basic and applied research, by first-entry visa (whether the first U.S. visa was a student visa)

Research activity	Student visa entrants	All other workers	
Basic research	36.0%	22.7%	<i>Universe: full-time/full-year workers. Unweighted n: entered on student visa = 6,430; all other workers = 58,199.</i>
Applied research	42.5%	27.4%	

9 Federal agency support

Share of workers whose principal-job work is supported by each U.S. federal agency, shown two ways: by current student-visa status and by first-entry visa. Because work can be backed by more than one agency (“mark all that apply”), the agency rows overlap and need not sum to the “any federal support” row.

Table 10: Federal agency support, by current student-visa status

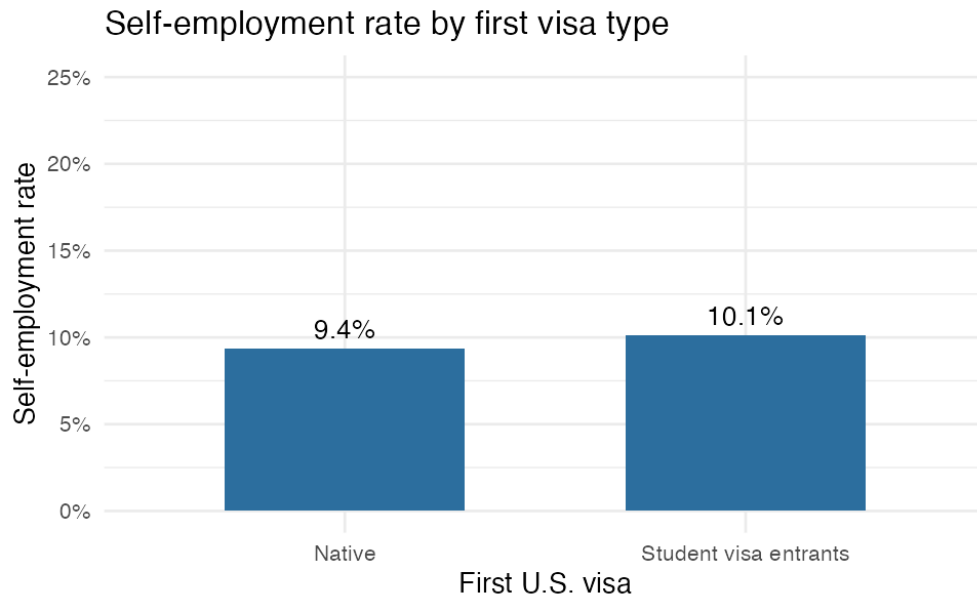
Federal agency	Current student visa holders	All other workers	
Any federal support	20.5%	11.2%	<i>Agencies overlap (mark all that apply). Unweighted n: current student visa = 618; all other workers = 68,052.</i>
NIH	7.4%	1.0%	
NSF	8.1%	0.4%	
Other agency	2.4%	3.0%	
Defense (DOD)	0.9%	2.6%	
HHS (excl. NIH)	0.5%	1.8%	
Energy (DOE)	1.9%	0.6%	
Education	0.6%	1.8%	
NASA	0.6%	0.4%	

Table 11: Federal agency support, by first-entry visa

Federal agency	Student visa entrants	All other workers	
Any federal support	10.9%	11.2%	
NIH	3.6%	1.0%	
NSF	2.0%	0.4%	
Other agency	1.7%	3.0%	<i>Agencies overlap (mark all that apply).</i>
Defense (DOD)	1.2%	2.6%	
HHS (excl. NIH)	1.1%	1.8%	
Energy (DOE)	0.9%	0.5%	
Education	0.8%	1.8%	
NASA	0.5%	0.4%	

apply). Unweighted n: entered on student visa = 6,702; all other workers = 61,968.

10 Self-employment

**Figure 2:** Self-employment rate by first visa type**Table 12:** Self-employment rate by first visa type

Visa type	Self-employed (wt.)	Not (wt.)	Rate
Native	4,606,497	44,579,039	9.4%
Student visa entrants	211,574	1,875,050	10.1%

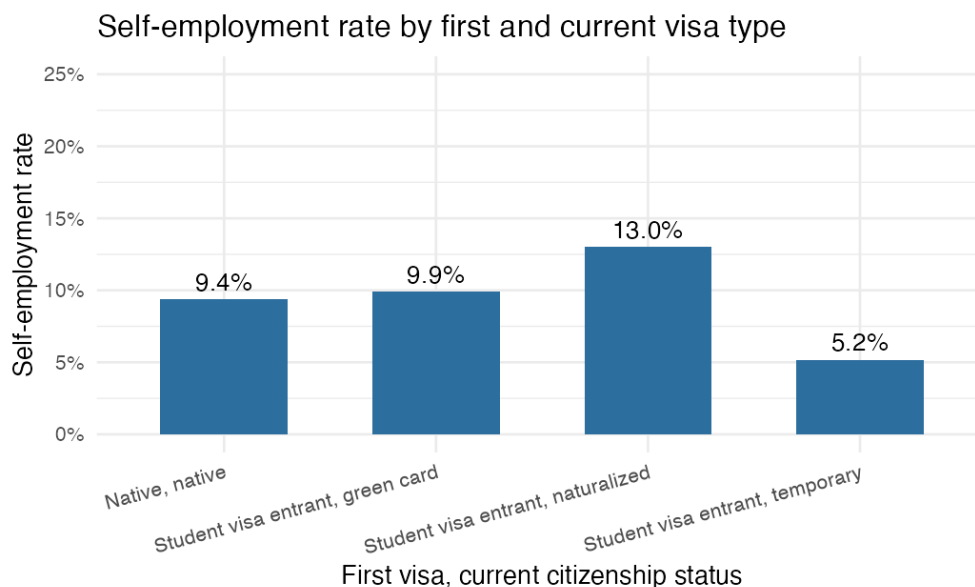


Figure 3: Self-employment rate by first and current visa/citizenship status

Table 13: Self-employment rate by first and current status

First visa, current status	Self-employed (wt.)	Not (wt.)	Rate
Native, native	4,599,686	44,555,832	9.4%
Student visa entrant, green card	54,170	493,032	9.9%
Student visa entrant, naturalized	129,346	864,618	13.0%
Student visa entrant, temporary	28,057	515,771	5.2%

11 Current status of student-visa entrants

Where student-visa entrants (full-time/full-year) stand today, by current citizenship status.

Table 14: Current citizenship status of student-visa entrants (weighted)

Current citizenship status	Weighted total
naturalized	993,964
green card	547,203
temporary	543,828
native	1,629

A Unweighted sample sizes by industry

Raw (unweighted) record counts underlying the industry salary table, showing why several industries are dropped.

Table 15: Unweighted respondent counts by industry and group

Industry	Native	Student visa entrants
Prof services	11,258	2,103
Ed and HC	11,658	1,524
Manufacturing	7,209	1,151
FIRE	3,150	470
Information	1,248	295
Retail Trade	1,251	216
Public Admin	5,201	209
Trans/WH, Util	1,535	126
Agriculture	577	57
Accom & Food	689	54
Other Services	962	54
Wholesale Trade	496	50
Military	153	1